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Salafism in contemporary Ethiopia

A Review Analysis of: "Salafism and the local: Negotiation, accommodation and Re-localisation of Ethiopian Salafism" by Østebø, T. & Tsehayu, Y. G.

&

"Localising Salafism: Religious Change among Oromo Muslims in Bale, Ethiopia" by Østebø, T.

Brenner, Adrian Tilman Lysander
E-mail: Adrian.Brenner@uni-bayreuth.de
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Abstract

This paper presents a short and general reflective review in form of an analysis of the history and current developments of Salafism in modern Ethiopia under the guiding texts by Østebø and Tsehayu (2024) & again Østebø (2012). The text aims to investigate what defines modern Ethiopian Salafism. It analyses the evolution of Salafi-related history in Ethiopia, how it has transitioned from an isolationist movement concerned with religious purity into a more complex, re-localised phenomenon driven by a new generation of Ethiopian Muslims. The reflective analysis is followed by a small discussion on the movements impact on wider society and a conclusive outlook.

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Abbreviations

In alphabetical order

EIASC	Ethiopian Islamic Affairs Supreme Council
EOC	Ethiopian Orthodox Church
EPRDF	Ethiopian People's Revolutionary Democratic Front
FDRE	Federal Democratic Republic of Ethiopia

1. Introduction

Salafism(s) today exert a notable influence not only in the Middle East and North Africa, regions which might first be coming to mind in connection with that term, but also in Sub-Saharan Africa, especially in the Sahel and West Africa. Another region which however also presents significant salafism-related developments over the last few decades is the Horn of Africa. In Ethiopia the ideas behind such movements are deeply rooted in Muslim-oriented society, having a long standing and close relation to the Arabian peninsula and thus being connected with the core of Muslim identity over multiple centuries.

Within Muslim communities in contemporary Ethiopia, which constitute approximately 34% of the population and are very dominant across the east of the country,[1] Salafi movements have spread particularly fast over the last three decades as a way of civil society to express itself. Drawing from Østebø (2012), this influence manifests itself through ongoing ideological adaptations that intersect with local socio-political realities, fostering a shift toward greater integration with broader Ethiopian contexts. In these recent years, Salafism[2] has moreover transitioned from a more traditional and exclusivist stance to one characterized by negotiation and social debate, driven by a new, urban generation and political change (Østebø and Tsehayu, 2024, p. 10-12).

This has led to the Ethiopian Salafi movement playing an increasing role in addressing immediate concerns such as national belonging, social standing or economic participation rather than solely focusing on religious purity. However, this evolution also contributes to tensions, including intra-Muslim debates and conflicts with state authorities over issues like religious education, secularism and public expression within Muslim dominated regions of the country. Overall, the true impact of Salafism in Ethiopia remains hard to pinpoint. What then actually defines modern Ethiopian Salafism, how is it different or similar to other Salafi movements? Does it address the differences between generations or its followers economic situations? Do current trends signal a clear no-return to its roots and is it rather becoming a socio-political reform movement?

2. Salafi Roots in Ethiopia

Islam in Ethiopia is ancient, dating back to 613 AD when Prophet Muhammad advised his companions to seek refuge from persecution in the Aksumite Empire (part of modern-day Ethiopia). Despite such long lasting connections with the religion, Muslims were historically marginalized by the Ethiopian Orthodox Church (EOC) (Østebø and Tsehayu, 2024, p. 7). The EOC's hegemony and a national narrative that depicted Ethiopia as a Christian society often cast Muslims as a foreign community, leading to their treatment as 2nd

[1] For the religious distribution in the country, see: (Figure 1: Religion in Ethiopia.)

[2] The study defines "Salafism" as an etic term derived from al-salaf al-ṣāliḥ ("the pious ancestors"). Although the research links this term to the tradition stemming from Ibn 'Abd al-Wahhāb, the author deliberately avoids "Wahhabism" because of its pejorative connotation, which is rejected by the informants. Furthermore, the Salafism discussed in the text differs from the 19th-century modernist Egyptian Salafiyya movement (led by figures such as Muḥammad 'Abduh and Jamāl al-Dīn al-Afghāni), which had different origins and later evolved into a different political current (Østebø, 2012, p. 24f).

class citizens. Historically, for example, the conversion of the "Emperor to be" Lij Iyasu to Islam, was met with a swift ousting of him by the Orthodox oligarchy, clearly demonstrating and adding to the perception that the Ethiopian state was hostile to Muslim identity. This systemic marginalization forced a long-standing "politics of withdrawal", where many Muslims secluded themselves from public life to protect their limited religious space. While the old Shafi'i school has remained the predominant Sunni tradition in the country until today, the domestic Islamic landscape began to shift with the arrival of Salafistic interpretations during the Italian occupation (1935-42). During this period, Fascist Italy deployed a "Pro-Islamic strategy" to garner local support and undermine the previous Ethiopian leadership in Muslim dominated areas across the Horn of Africa (Østebø and Tsehayu, 2024, p. 5). Despite this strategy, the movement did not really take off with this external attempt.

Other Salafi movements expanded significantly further however in the 1960s. They were characterized by a drive for religious purity by elders. As the regions in Ethiopia lacked established Islamic scholarship and textual resources, locals were less equipped to resist the scriptural demands for legitimacy, facilitating the movements' acceptance. This Ethiopian Salafism wave focused heavily on questioning local practices and Sufism, labeling them as bid'a (unlawful innovations) and shirk (the association of partners with God). This movement initially maintained an isolationist stance, arguing that Muslims should withdraw from politics to avoid fitna (conflict) and hizbiyya (divisions) (Østebø and Tsehayu, 2024, p. 6f). These increased "politics of withdrawal" were not only ideological but also a pragmatic response to a state that often viewed any stronger Islamic movements as a source of political radicalization and threats.

Onto this development followed the Cold War which fully reached Ethiopia, when the long standing Imperial State was overthrown and the Marxist Derg (ደርግ)[3] regime took over (1974–1991). The Derg initially checked Salafi expansion but inadvertently aided its consolidation. While dominant traditional religious institutions and practices suffered under the regime's secularizing policies and repressive measures, Salafism institutionalized itself, e.g., in Bale through the Salafiyya Madrasa and the Nūr mosque in Robe, thereby securing control over religious knowledge (Østebø, 2012, p. 222f). The Derg's emphasis on academic rationalism and modernisation aligned with the Salafi focus on tawḥīd (Oneness of God, having no equal), leading to a de-mystification of reality and challenging the belief in karaama (spiritual power) inherent in objects and individuals. This prepared the "generation of the Derg," alienated from past traditions, to more readily embrace Salafism after 1991 (Østebø and Tsehayu, 2024, p. 6).

With the fall of Addis Ababa, the end of the Derg in 1991, and the establishment of the new Federal Democratic Republic of Ethiopia (FDRE) under the Ethiopian People's Revolutionary Democratic Forces (EPRDF) led to a new secular constitution in 1994 that enshrined religious and ethnic freedom (Østebø and Tsehayu, 2024, p. 5f). In this new environment, Salafism became one of Ethiopia's dominant Islamic reform movements, focusing on rebuilding marginalized communities through personal engagement. Due to

[3]Translation: Committee.

its informal and decentered nature, this generation of Muslims often did not identify as "Salafis", but simply as "Islamic", creating a prioritization of personal devotion and strengthening of religious practice (Østebø and Tsehayu, 2024, p. 6).

3. Contemporary Developments and Analysis

As explored in the previous section, Ethiopian Salafism was mainly characterized by religious purity and withdrawal, focusing on combating bid'a and shirk. However, the movement is undergoing a change, as a new generation of urban, educated Muslims seeks to claim space as both Ethiopians and Muslims, moving away from withdrawal toward active engagement in the country's socio-economic and political life (Østebø and Tsehayu, 2024, p. 9). This trajectory of Salafism in Ethiopia over the last decade has been defined by internal changes in broader Ethiopian society and politics. This has led to Salafism's role in addressing immediate concerns such as national belonging, economic participation, and interfaith relations, rather than solely focusing on doctrinal purity. Yet, this evolution also contributes to tensions between certain Muslim communities or conflicts with state authorities over things like religious education and public expression. Crucially, it is a conceptual shift away from the "globalized paradigm" of Salafism, which tends to construe the movement as de-culturalized and de-territorialized. Instead, the argument presented by Østebø (2012) is that ongoing changes are not results of detached ideological developments or trans-local ideological flows, but rather that local and situated discourses are the dominant force in decision-making (Østebø, 2012, p. xix, xx).

3.1 Localisation

Ethiopian Salafism exhibits distinct local characteristics shaped by the country's unique historical, cultural, and political landscape, setting it apart from manifestations in ,e.g., West Africa or the Middle East. In Ethiopia, Salafism has become deeply embedded in specific ethnic contexts, such as among the Oromo in regions like Bale, where it intersects with indigenous traditions and resistance to historical Amhara-Christian hegemony (Østebø, 2012, p. 200). This produces a "re-localised" form of the movement that accommodates local customs and addresses immediate socio-economic challenges, contrasting with some West African Salafism movements, which contend with entrenched Sufi movements or aim to dismantle colonial legacies that emphasize communal rituals over individual reform. In comparison, Ethiopian Salafism readily navigates a Christian-majority state, fostering pragmatic accommodations with Orthodox Christianity and state secularism.

This perspective is essential for comprehending Salafism's heterogeneity and its specific trajectory in Ethiopia. If global Salafism represents a river (the impetus, meaning outside influence), the analytical task is not to observe its flow but to study how the water transforms through local terrain and the absorption of local minerals" (Østebø, 2012, p. 22-26). Religious change thus emerges as a dynamic, multifaceted and deeply

localised process, resisting characterization as a monolithic or exclusively foreign phenomenon.[4]

The concept of localisation[5] captures how Salafism is remolded in the Ethiopian case: Locality as social space shaped by human experience and relations, the discursive tradition of Islam, which develops in dialogue with existing religious culture and the traditions of civil society. This framework further engages with modernisation as a vernacular process, "vernacular modernism", experienced and appropriated differently across localities, rather than as a uniform external force (Østebø, 2012, p. 38).[6]

3.2 National Developments

In contemporary times a generation shift has moreover fundamentally reshaped Ethiopian Salafism, actively moving it from isolation towards active national engagement. The turning point for the movement was the Ethiopian government's decision in 2011 to promote the Lebanese al-Ahbash movement, which views Salafism as extremism. This led to protests, known as Dimtsachin Yisema (ድምፃችን ይሰማ)[7] from 2011 to 2013. It emerged in protest against said government interference in religious affairs, propelling young Muslims into political activism (Østebø and Tsehayu, 2024, p. 9). The key was that the government violated the constitutional secular principle by unlawfully interfering in religious affairs. Although the protests were violently suppressed, the Dimtsachin Yisema movement functioned as an important "network of meaning", forcing participants, especially the youth, to review their own political (non-)activism (Østebø and Tsehayu, 2024, p. 10f). This engagement necessitated formulating a framework for how to engage with politics and made it increasingly difficult to separate "moral selves from political selves". In addition it highlighted the limitations of the traditional Salafi curriculum, forcing Salafis to address political and civil rights rather than maintaining traditional withdrawal.

Central to this transformation is the rise of the Ustazes (ኡስታዝ)[8]. Unlike the, now much older, isolationist Shimageles (ሽማግሌ)[9], these figures are university-educated autodidacts who leverage social media to reach mass audiences, addressing issues of employment, public service or political representation that their predecessors neglected. Their pragmatic approach transgresses older ideological boundaries, reframing activism within an Islamic identity (Østebø and Tsehayu, 2024, p. 12f). Many were imprisoned under the EPRDF after the Dimtsachin Yisema protests but were released in 2018 alongside major political changes in Ethiopia. The Ustazes translate their influence into institutional forms: Establishing NGOs for Muslim empowerment,

[4]Religious change is defined by the author with two essential criteria: It possesses an intentional aspect, implemented deliberately by agents of change with explicit strategies, and it proceeds at a rapid pace within a relatively limited timeframe, distinguishing it from slower processes of cultural acculturation (Østebø, 2012, p. 14f).

[5]Localisation refers to how indigenous actors simultaneously reinterpret, configure and customize the religious impetus according to specific political, economic, cultural, and historical circumstances (Østebø, 2012, p. 35f).

[6]On the other hand de-localisation describes how the incoming ideology detaches from its place of origin (notably Saudi Arabia) while simultaneously rejecting local traditions in the receiving environment (Østebø, 2012, p. 36).

[7]Translation: Let Our Voice be Heard. Can also be written *Dimtsachen Yesima*.

[8]Translation: Teachers.

[9]Translation: Seniors. These were the generational wave establishing and institutionalizing the movement in the 1960s.

creating Islamic financial institutions or entering formal politics through, e.g., the Freedom and Equality Party (ነጻነትና እኩልነት ፓርቲ)[10] (Østebø and Tsehayu, 2024, p. 13).

This new generation has compelled the Shimageles to negotiate their previously exclusivist positions. Facing declining legitimacy among the youth which perceives their messages as "boring and irrelevant", fixated only on bid'a and shirk while ignoring socio-economic realities. Some Shimageles have remained silent and "accepted" the Ustaz taking over while these developments led others to restructure the Ethiopian Islamic Affairs Supreme Council (EIASC) in 2022. This change coincides with diminishing Saudi financial means, which were mainly received by the Shimageles, following Crown Prince Muhammad bin Salman's numerous religious reforms in the 2010s and ongoing 2020s. This has curtailed external enforcement of purist agendas and created space for Ethiopian Muslims to develop locally-grounded Islamic expressions (Østebø and Tsehayu, 2024, p. 15f). The Ethiopian case thus demonstrates how religious authority is continuously renegotiated, with Salafism emerging not as a monolithic import but as the cumulative product of competing local voices and generational contestation.

The "Post Dimtsachin Yisema generation", now in their late teenage years and early 20s, is increasingly integrated into Ethiopian society.[11] They start to reinterpret society, alongside the guiding of the Ustazes, as they advocate contextualizing religious practices according to current Ethiopian realities, challenging formerly rigid markers like dress codes and increasingly reclaim indigenous traditions, e.g., celebrating mawlid al-nabi (the Prophet's birthday) and menzuma (indigenous praise songs), which earlier Salafis had condemned as unlawful bid'a. This also resulted in a renewed interest in Ethiopian Islamic heritage, including Sufi scholarships. Most significantly, they assert active citizenship, refusing to compartmentalise their Muslim identity from participating in their ethnic/national life, leaving the long-standing "politics of withdrawal" behind. Gender debates also flare up as young women are more vocal about their own identity, e.g., education, increasing interactions with non-muslims or working rights (Østebø and Tsehayu, 2024, p. 11). Due to the country's demographics this generation is greater in number and therefore gains increasing influence.

These changes are driven on alongside national socio-political developments. The EPRDF was dissolved by its last Prime minister Abiy Ahmed Ali in 2019 and replaced by the pan-ethnic Prosperity Party (ብልጽግና ፓርቲ), which became the singular "official" acting political force in the country. Abiy, a devoted pentecostal Christian, frequently breaches secularism with religious statements, as such he also released the Ustazes in 2018 and deemed their religious activism legitimate (Østebø and Tsehayu, 2024, p. 13). Under the Prosperity Party Regime Abiy Ahmed however increasingly dominates society. The "unifying" national principle of Medemer (መደመር)[12] is defining country-wide identity politics in the 2020s. Per this principle religious, ethnic or class identifications "hinder" progress as per Medemer and should not interfere with national goals.

[10] See: (Figure 2: Logo of the Freedom and Equality Party)

[11] Integration meaning increased access to: Media, Internet, Infrastructure, Education and the private sector.

[12] Translation: Togetherness.

Here the Salafi movement becomes a refuge for young people to still meet in civil society and connect beyond the state's doctrine.

Contemporary Ethiopian Salafism as such is not part of a global phenomenon but local movements establishing their own or unified voices in the context of repressive Ethiopian politics. Its followers are less traditional and more politically active. Religious identity is not alone but a part of the same ethnic, local, economic identity. All these dynamics constitute the emergence of "Post-Salafism", with "Post" not implying Salafism is disappearing. It denotes the Salafi trend as a reform movement (Østebø and Tsehayu, 2024, p. 16).

4. Conclusion and Discussion

In conclusion, Salafism in Ethiopia is best understood as the cumulative product of localised adaptations, whereby its evolution is attributed not to abstract ideological shifts but to situated discourses embedded in specific historical, socio-political, and generational contexts. These include centuries of Christian hegemony under the EOC, the secular policies of the Derg, expansion during the early years under the EPRDF and suppression in the 2010s leading to an increasingly politicized younger generation. In Ethiopia, modern Salafism's uniqueness lies further in its negotiation with urbanized dynamics, resulting in rapid modernisation. This positions Ethiopian Salafism as a distinct Salafi stream: It integrates with practices, reducing communal polarization and prioritizes accommodation over dominance, thereby creating a unique path within a pluralistic state.

Instrumentalization under Abiy Ahmed's new administration however destabilizes this path, exacerbating divides and risking fragmentation if generational contestations intensify without inclusive dialogue. Ultimately, fostering policy frameworks that support religious pluralism could, despite this recent trend, amplify Salafism's constructive influence, preventing religious escalations seen in other regions. This perspective, drawn from Østebø and Tsehayu (2024) and Østebø (2012) suggests optimism for Salafism's adaptive potential in Ethiopia's future.

Østebø and Tsehayu (2024) conclude that due to these rapidly developing factors Ethiopian Salafism is currently in the previously mentioned state of "post-Salafism". Meaning the movement is undergoing an urban and increasingly younger re-localisation where local political and socio-economic dynamics are more influential than global ideological flows or individual bid'a. The decline of Saudi financial support has further accelerated the movements change towards independence, allowing Ethiopian Muslims to develop their own interpretations that are better suited to their immediate, everyday lives. Ultimately, the movement is now understood by the new generation as a flexible framework that must accommodate the complexities of their own modern Ethiopian identity rather than a rigid, isolated set of behavior dictated by others.

Appendix

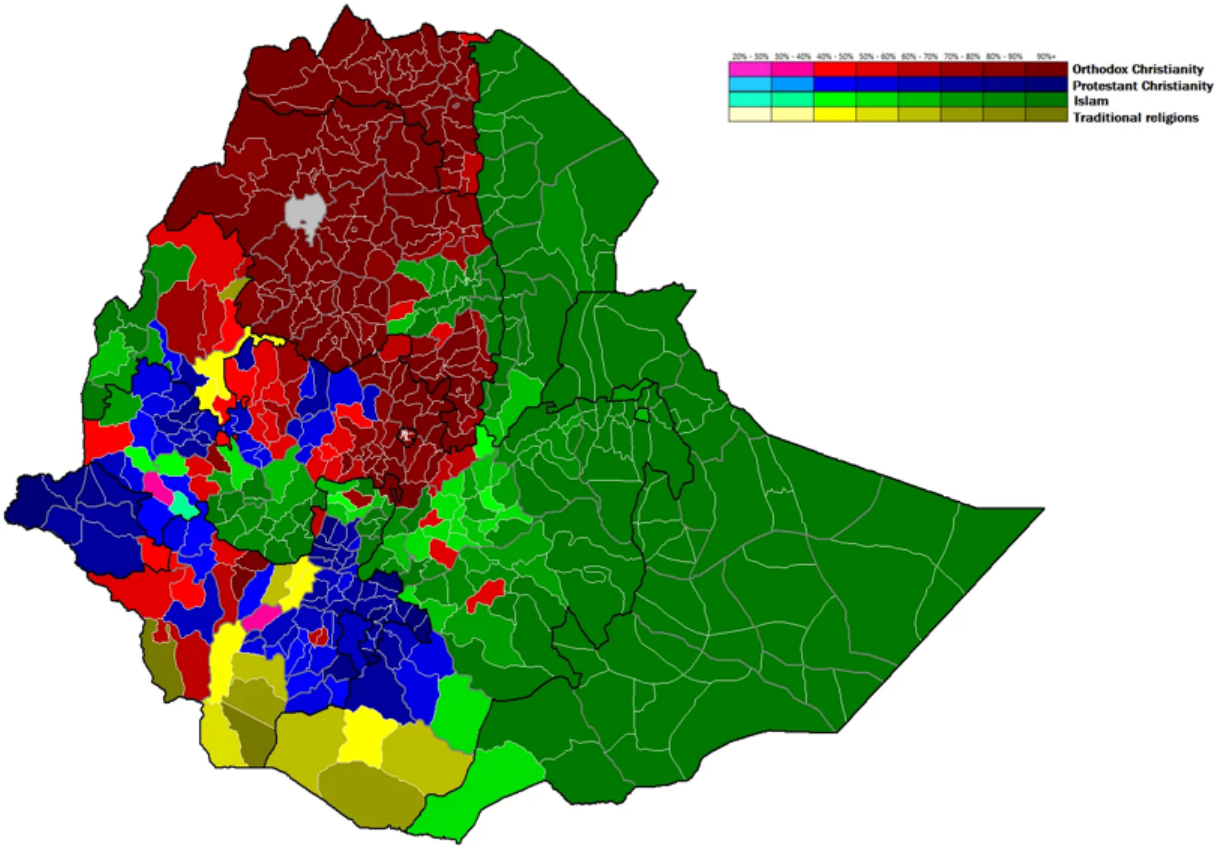


Figure 1: Religion in Ethiopia (Lewis, 2021)



Figure 2: Logo of the Freedom and Equality Party (Freedom and Equality Party, 2026)

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